

SUPERMAN REDRAWN

Legendary comic artist John Romita Jr reflects on his first year of drawing the iconic Superman and talks new powers and costumes

If you follow his adventures in the comics, you'll know that Superman has had an eventful few months.
One of the big talking points recently was *Superman* #38, on sale last month, which saw him unleash a new power that he did not realise he had on unsuspecting antagonist Ulysses. This reveal was followed by him donning a new costume – a tweaked version of the New 52 threads – and a major change in his relationship with pal Jimmy Olsen.

The issue was the final part of a story by superstar DC writer Geoff Johns and artist John Romita Jr, best known for his extensive work at Marvel, dating back to the Seventies. It could be said that Marvel was in his blood, with his father, John Romita Sr, the first artist to take over from Steve Ditko on *The Amazing Spider-Man* under Stan Lee. In later years, Romita Jr (who refers to himself as JRJR) forged his own relationship with the character, perhaps most famously in the December 2001 issue, where Spider-Man deals with the fallout of the September 11 attacks.

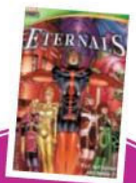
But Romita Jr has drawn just about every Marvel character there is, including the *Kick-Ass* series with writer Mark Millar. As the recent events in *Superman* prove, sometimes you need to shake things up, and when an opportunity to move to DC came along, working with Geoff Johns and inker Klaus Janson on such an iconic hero, it seemed like a change that was needed. It looks like it paid off too, as Romita Jr will no doubt reveal when he visits the UK for the London Super Comic Con this month.

You've been drawing Superman for almost a year now. How have you found it?
The whole process has been a lot of fun, and the editors and Geoff Johns have been a great pleasure to work with. What I had been concerned with, regarding the change in characters and the two companies, I thought it would be much more tumultuous, it wasn't… it was basically just a change in the type of costume I was drawing, and wasn't as big a move as I expected. I still got to do the same thing I'd been doing for the last 35 years.

It must have been strange switching companies after that time…
How it happened, I was interested in doing creator-owned properties at Marvel, similar to *Kick-Ass*, as I didn't want to just stick with the mainstream work. So I talked to them about it, but then my contract expired and we were having discussions back and forth. DC got in touch, and my wife, Kathy, had always been interested in me working there because she wanted to see the difference, and even my father signed off on it. He said, "Hey, don't just carry on working for Marvel, do what is best for you." A lot of other people were supportive, and while I wanted something new, I hadn't really planned on changing companies; it just happened. But I'm very happy, and I'm thrilled to be doing *Superman*.

How did it feel to draw the character first of all? He's been around for over 75 years…
I actually had a little bit of an anxiety attack the first time I did it, saying to myself, "I am drawing the oldest and most revered superhero in comics – there are so many guys who have done this before me. What am I going to do?" But literally the moment I first drew the cape, I thought, "Wait a minute, I've drawn a character with a cape before, this is kind of cool." So I felt a lot more comfortable. And the way you handle the character is not dissimilar to the way you might handle Thor, in terms of his power. Then it was just a matter of getting the jawline and the hair right.

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> JOHN ROMITA JR



The best of John Romita Jr

The Eternals (2006)
Romita Jr helped writer Neil Gaiman with this seven-issue mini-series that reintroduced Jack Kirby's Seventies characters to the modern Marvel universe.

You've drawn DC characters before, though – at Marvel you drew the cover for a DC/Marvel Crossover Classics trade paperback, and there was the *Batman Vs Punisher* special…
That's correct, and that's why I always imagined I would do Batman again at some point, but instead I'm doing Superman, the very character that I didn't care for several years ago because I thought he was just too perfect. But I found the ideas that Geoff [Johns] had were amazing.

They all seemed to come to fruition in *Superman* #38 with the new 'Super Flare' power and the costume changes. Were you part of all that?
The editors of the *Superman* books had been talking about it for a while and asking, "Couldn't we do something with Superman's powers, maybe show another side to them, something that manifests? It's not something we've shaken up in a while." So myself, Greg Pak, Gene Luen Yang, Aaron Kuder and Pete Tomasi threw a few ideas around, and along with Geoff [Johns] came up with an extension of his regular abilities [the flare is a powerful blast caused by Superman expelling all of the solar energy from his cells at once, discovered by accident]. The fact that it happened in the first story arc I worked on was pure luck on my side, but it'll play into all of the other books. His costume got destroyed by that, so he makes a new one with a few tweaks. The changes are pretty minimal, as it's so iconic there isn't a lot you can do. We just wanted to freshen it a little, and we did it at a point when the old one was damaged, so it makes sense.

This is a power that also weakens Superman after he uses it – no more solar energy means he is basically mortal for 24 hours until he recharges…
That's right. And it's Batman who tells him this when he wakes up in the Batcave, which means I got to do a brief but vital